2.3 The Format Scoring System - Rank Every Station Like an Analyst

Elite private strategy - not for redistribution

WAR-ROOM NOTES - 2.3 The Format Scoring System

THE SCORECARD IS A RISK MODEL, NOT A POPULARITY CONTEST

The 30-point format-fit weight is the single largest factor because a format mismatch is the one failure you cannot fix with marketing. The 25-point response-history weight is the second-largest because it measures your history with the station - a warm inbox is worth more than a big signal. Reach is deliberately the smallest permanent factor (10 points) because big stations with low fit and zero relationship are where independents go to die. Weighted correctly, the scorecard tells you where the wins live - not where the fame is.

THE 12-POINT CHECK HAS A SECRET: THE 12-SECOND RULE

Most PDs make an add/ding decision inside the first 12 seconds of a song. If your hook isn't inside 12 seconds, the format score doesn't matter - the song is out. This is the most commonly failed point on the check and the easiest to fix: cut to the hook, or re-edit the single. Radio edits are not compromises; they're admissions that you understand the customer.

SPECIALTY IS THE UNDERPRICED ENTRY RAMP

Late-night, local-focus, and genre-specific shows have the highest acceptance rate in radio because they have inventory pressure - they must fill time with new music. A specialty add is worth the same proof as a morning show add and costs 20% of the effort. Strategy: aim the first campaign at specialty + college + community (platform cut), collect 3-5 adds, then convert those into a commercial-format pitch with the proof.

THE 90-DAY RECHECK DISCIPLINE

Scores are fingerprints, not bedrock. Formats change, program directors change, your catalog changes. Every 90 days re-score the C-tier and re-scan the market - the station that was mismatched last quarter may have a new night show, a new specialty slot, or a new format. The audit engine in Module 6 runs this loop automatically.

THE ANALYST'S ONE-LINE RULE (NEVER VIOLATE)

Never pitch a station whose 12-point fit check you haven't run. One line of arrogance here costs one burned well. The scorecard exists to keep your ego out of the targeting process - let the numbers do the deciding.